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ACADEMIC VAULT

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GST 102: Use of English II - Essays, Letters and Advanced Comprehension

Write the essays, letters and reports that university assessment actually rewards

GST / COMPULSORY

GST & Compulsory Courses

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

Study smarter. Ask better questions. Pass with understanding.

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

GST 102 moves from sentence rules to whole pieces of writing. This pack gives you reusable structures for argumentative and expository essays, formal letters, reports and minutes, plus a marking-style checklist so you can grade your own drafts before your lecturer does.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Plan an argumentative or expository essay in five minutes using a clear thesis and paragraph outline.
- Write a formal letter, application letter and simple report with correct layout and register.
- Use cohesive devices without overusing 'moreover' and 'furthermore'.
- Edit your own draft for structure, grammar, punctuation and word choice.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

The five-minute essay plan

Most weak essays fail at the planning stage. Five minutes of planning saves twenty minutes of confused writing.

1. Underline the instruction words: discuss, argue, compare, describe, evaluate. Each demands a different structure.
2. Write a one-sentence thesis: the exact position your essay will defend.
3. List three body points. Each must be different, relevant and supportable.
4. For each body point, note one example or piece of evidence.
5. Decide your conclusion in one sentence before you start writing.

The thesis test
If your thesis could be agreed with by everyone, it is too vague. 'Technology is useful' is not a thesis. 'Smartphones help freshers study only when notifications are controlled' is.

Paragraph architecture

A body paragraph should do one job: prove one point. The most reliable pattern is claim, explanation, evidence, link.

- Claim: a topic sentence that states the point directly.
- Explanation: why the claim is true in your context.
- Evidence: an example, statistic, experience or reference.
- Link: connect back to the thesis or forward to the next point.
- Keep paragraphs between four and eight sentences. Very long paragraphs hide your argument.

Argumentative versus expository essays

Both need structure, but they answer different questions.

- Argumentative: take a side, acknowledge the strongest opposing view, then rebut it. Do not sit on the fence unless the question asks you to.
- Expository: explain a process, concept or phenomenon clearly. Your job is clarity, not persuasion.
- Narrative: tell a story with a point. Avoid ending with 'and that was how I learnt a lesson' unless the lesson is specific.
- Compare and contrast: organise by criteria (cost, speed, reliability) rather than describing one item fully and then the other.

Counter-argument formula
Some students argue that X because Y. That view has merit, but it overlooks Z. When Z is considered, X becomes less convincing than it first appears.

Formal letters without embarrassment

Formal letters are marked on layout, tone and completeness as much as on grammar.

- Two addresses: your address, then the recipient's address, then the date.
- Salutation: 'Dear Sir/Madam' when the name is unknown; 'Dear Mr Okafor' when known.
- Subject line: short and specific, for example 'Application for the Position of Library Assistant'.
- Opening: state your purpose in the first two sentences. Do not begin with 'I am writing this letter to tell you that'.
- Body: one paragraph per issue. Be direct and courteous.
- Closing: 'Yours faithfully' after 'Dear Sir/Madam'; 'Yours sincerely' after a named recipient.
- Sign and print your full name.

Reports and minutes

A report answers a question for someone who was not there. Minutes record decisions, not conversations.

- Report structure: title, terms of reference, procedure, findings, conclusion, recommendations.
- Write findings as evidence, not opinion: 'Twenty of 30 students surveyed...' not 'Everybody knows...'.
- Minutes: date, time, venue, attendance, agenda items, decisions, action owners, next meeting.
- Record decisions and action points, not every contribution.
- Use past tense for what happened and present tense for standing rules.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Write a thesis for: 'Should first-year students be allowed to use AI tools for assignments?'

Answer: A defensible thesis: 'First-year students should be allowed to use AI tools for drafting and feedback, provided they disclose the use and remain responsible for the final argument.' It takes a position and sets a condition.

2. Which salutation pairs with 'Yours faithfully'?

Answer: 'Dear Sir/Madam' pairs with 'Yours faithfully'. 'Yours sincerely' pairs with a named recipient.

3. What is the difference between an expository and an argumentative essay?

Answer: An expository essay explains a topic clearly. An argumentative essay takes a position and defends it against objections.

4. Rewrite in formal register: 'I wanna ask if you guys can give me the job.'

Answer: 'I would like to apply for the position and would appreciate the opportunity to discuss my suitability.'

5. What belongs in the findings section of a report?

Answer: Observed facts, data and evidence gathered through the stated procedure, presented without recommendations. Recommendations belong in their own section.

6. Give three cohesive devices for showing contrast.

Answer: However, nevertheless, by contrast, whereas, on the other hand. Use one per paragraph rather than stacking them.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Write one argumentative essay in 40 minutes using the five-minute plan.
- [ ] Write one formal application letter and check every layout element against the list in this pack.
- [ ] Convert a news article into a two-paragraph summary in your own words.
- [ ] Edit an old essay, marking every run-on sentence and pronoun ambiguity.
- [ ] Learn five new transition words and use each once in a paragraph.
- [ ] Write a one-page report on a campus problem with findings and recommendations.
- [ ] Ask a coursemate to identify your thesis from your introduction alone.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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